REFLECTION

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ مَن زَكَّاهَا

How Does the Soul Grow?

Ash-Shams 91:9

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REFLECTION

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Surah Ash-Shams and Surah Al-Mulk

In Surah Ash-Shams (91:7–10) Allah swears by the soul:

وَنَفْسٍ وَمَا سَوَّاهَا ۝٧ فَأَلْهَمَهَا فُجُورَهَا وَتَقْوَاهَا ۝٨ قَدْ أَفْلَحَ مَن زَكَّاهَا ۝٩ وَقَدْ خَابَ مَن دَسَّاهَا ۝١٠

"By the soul and the One who formed it, and showed it what is wrong for it and what is right: successful is the one who makes it grow pure, and lost is the one who buries it."

The word زَكَّاهَا (*zakkaahaa*) means both "purified it" and "made it grow", from the same root as *zakah*. And دَسَّاهَا (*dassaahaa*) means "buried it, smothered it".

How do we make it grow?

By deeds. In Surah Al-Mulk (67:2):

الَّذِى خَلَقَ الْمَوْتَ وَالْحَيَاةَ لِيَبْلُوَكُمْ أَيُّكُمْ أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا ۚ وَهُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْغَفُورُ ۝٢

"He created death and life to test which of you is best in deeds. He is the Mighty, the Forgiving."

Note: أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا "best in deeds", not "most in deeds". What counts as the best? Allah and His Messenger have told us:

1. Prayer, zakah, and honouring our parents.
2. Fasting, and Hajj for those who are able.
3. The rights of family and neighbours.
4. Encouraging good and stopping evil.
5. Reading the Qur'an and living by it.
6. Following the Sunnah of the Prophet ﷺ.
7. Respect for elders, and love and kindness to the young.

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